



CLOSE TO NATURE: (clockwise from left) Wipro's Technology Centre in Gurgaon; Olympia Tech Park in Chennai; BG House in Mumbai

for hundreds of species," says Rohan Parikh, head, sustainable development, Infosys. There is plenty of motivation. Going 'green' has become a differentiator for companies. The driving factor, of course, is the economics—it costs less and achieves a faster payback.

The Indian Green Building Council (IGBC) is targeting 1,000 LEED certified buildings by 2010, up from 140 now. At present, green buildings covering 67 million sq ft are being constructed all over the country, up from 20,000 sq ft in 2003. Assuming an average building covers 2 lakh sq ft, estimates S. Srinivas, principal counsellor and LEED-accredited professional at the CII-Godrej Green Building Council, Hyderabad, green buildings would have covered a footprint of 200 million sq ft and 1 billion sq ft by 2014. "Today, going green is a business mandate. Every customer asks, how green are you?" says Parikh. He is now incorporating LEED principles in his upcoming Jaipur campus.

The movement is being led by large companies such as Infosys, ITC, Wipro and Satyam. With green buildings already commanding a rental premium of three-five per cent and a better valuation in the West, Indian builders too are joining the fray. Mumbai-based Hiranandani Group, K. Raheja Universal, K. Raheja Corp, Bangalore-

based RMZ and Brigade Group and Delhi-based Vipul Group have committed to go in for green construction, whether owned or leased. Niranjana Hiranandani, managing director, Hiranandani Builders, says he is constructing about 50 million sq ft of green space in the next two-three years. Delhi-based Emaar MGF is developing the residential complex for the 2010 Commonwealth Games, which will be a certified green building. This has caught the fancy of architects such as Ahmedabad-based Karan Grover, Delhi-based Prem Jain and Mumbai-based Hafeez Contractor, who are now working on green buildings. Typically, the builders push the extra costs incurred in procuring eco-friendly materials—glazed glass, twin-flow toilets, solar panelling—on to the clients, who are happy with the overall savings in their utility bills.

Why are green buildings important? Buildings are energy-guzzlers, accounting for 30-40 per cent of global energy use. This means that improving energy efficiency there itself can help reduce global warming. It can not only cut one's power bill by as much as half, but also boost employee productivity by 12-15 per cent. But what is needed is a mix of suitable government regulations, greater use of energy saving technologies and a change in outlook.

All three seem to be happening. The Bureau of Energy Efficiency (BEE) has laid down the Energy Conservation Buildings Code (ECBC), which sets the minimum energy performance standards for design and construction of new commercial buildings with peak demand in excess of 500 kW. So if the energy consumption of a typical commercial building is 200 kwh per sq m per year, ECBC enforcement could reduce this to 120-160 kwh per sq m per year. The Ministry of Power expects savings of 1.7 billion units in the first year of implementation of ECBC norms. Although voluntary at present, BEE officials expect that the code will be made mandatory in three-five years. Even today all new commercial buildings which have an investment of over Rs 50 crore need to comply with ECBC standards and seek clearance from the Ministry of Environment and Forests. This holds true for buildings which are rated under LEED or the Green Rating

